confident that Gary had enough faith in me to also believe that I would not divulge what I had just told him to anyone else outside his room. But from his expression I could sense that what he wanted to tell me was that while I could say anything of the sort I had said to him and get away with it, if he had to say something similar to the prime minster, he should be carrying his resignation letter in his pocket and be prepared for harsh consequences. Instead, absolutely calm and composed, he told me that it would take him some time to find my replacements for the two divisions, and until then I should continue with my work as usual. He did not say anything about Punjab-related assignments, but it was implied that I would not be associated with anything like that in future.

There was no doubt that while subsequently briefing Kao about my visit to the US and Canada, Gary would have informed him of what I had said that morning. Kao, who had closely supervised my Sikkim operation (1973–1975) as secretary, knew that I would not say what I had without any basis. Besides, as senior advisor to the PM since August 1981, he was fully aware of what was happening at the decision-making level and knew who were influencing Indira Gandhi's decisions. His advice to Gary might have been to allow me a respite from such activities.

When I met Gary the next day in connection with some official work, things were normal, and he gave me the impression that nothing had happened the previous day. I was finally relieved of my two charges sometime in November 1983 and posted as deputy director in charge of an analysis division covering a fairly large area, of which Sri Lanka was an important part. That was the time when Sri Lanka was recovering from anti-Tamil riots that had caused the death of approximately 4,000 Tamils across that country in retaliation for the killing of thirteen Sri Lankan soldiers by the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) in an ambush at Jaffna on 23 July 1983.

That, in fact, marked the beginning of prolonged and fierce hostilities between the LTTE, other Sri Lankan Tamil militant groups such as the Peoples Liberation Organization of Tamil Elam (PLOTE), Eelam People's Revolutionary Liberation Front (EPRLF),